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MGB cuts were long time coming

Some question decisions amid consolidation

By Jessica Bartlett
GLOBE STAFF

Even as he found out his role at Mass General Brigham would be eliminated, Dr. Andrew Warshaw understood the decision was necessary.

The former chief of surgery at Massachusetts General Hospital has worked for over a decade in network development, helping expand the health care system's group of hospitals and services, an important role for the organization's mission and growth. But executives explained to him there were lots of other people doing the same job across the system, plus unnecessary layers of administration made the work less efficient.

His job was cut as part of the first round of what will be the largest layoffs in the health system's history, expected to reportedly total about 1,500 positions in two waves between this week and March. Warshaw was lucky, though: He expects to stay on in a different role at MGB.

"There is always pain in change," he said. "I have reasonable confidence we will get through this painful period and that the end result will be a more productive system."

The layoffs, which are slated to save over \$200 million from MGB's \$10.3 billion salary and benefits expenses, are part of a broader joining of services across the sprawling 12-hospital MGB, **Page A6**



Dozens of couples celebrated Valentine's Day this year by getting married at Boston City Hall. **B1.**

The crew of the Army helicopter that collided with a jet near Ronald Reagan National Airport may have had inaccurate altitude readings, investigators said. **A10.**

A drone armed with a warhead hit the protective outer shell of Ukraine's Chernobyl nuclear plant, punching a hole in the structure. **A5.**

The University of Massachusetts announced a \$35 million pledge from the family of produce magnate Paul J. DiMare. **D1.**



In the mix

Saturday: Snow, wintry mix. High: 29-34. Low: 25-30.

Sunday: Breezy, rainy. High: 34-39. Low: 19-24.

Sunrise: 6:40 Sunset: 5:17
Comics and Weather, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

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'This has been slash and burn.'

NICHOLAS DETTER, *Agriculture Department employee who had been helping farmers reduce erosion, who was fired by email late Thursday*

Federal workers face mass layoffs



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

Jean-Luc Pierite, president of the North American Indian Center of Boston, marched during a protest in downtown Boston on Friday. **B2.**

'We are gathered in a moment of turmoil'

Lack of clarity from D.C. has scientists on edge

By Danny McDonald
GLOBE STAFF

The question was meant as a moment of levity, but it cut to the trepidation of scientific communities across the nation in the early days of President Trump's new administration.

"Is anyone else here concerned?" Melissa Varga asked a room full of scientists at the Hynes Convention Center this week.

The line was met with laughs inside the nondescript room, where Varga, the science network senior manager for the Cambridge-based Union of Concerned Scientists, was addressing the annual meeting of the American Association for the Advancement of Science. More than a hundred scientists, engineers, researchers, and academics from across the country, and a few from abroad, gathered for a town hall forum as part of the annual meeting of the American Association for the Advancement of Science.

The political backdrop of the meeting was recognized. **SCIENTISTS, Page A6**

Vance's advice

The vice president told European leaders they threaten democracy by sidelining parties considered extremist. **A7.**

AGs' criticism

Andrea Campbell and more than a dozen peers criticized Vice President JD Vance for saying the courts did not have authority to infringe on the president's power. **B1.**

Across the country, notices are greeted with anger and uncertainty

By Jill Colvin, Brian Witte, Mike Householder, and Michelle L. Price
ASSOCIATED PRESS

NEW YORK — Workers across the country responded with anger and confusion Friday as they grappled with the Trump administration's aggressive effort to shrink the size of the federal workforce by ordering agencies to lay off potentially thousands of probationary employees who have yet to qualify for civil service protections.

While much of the administration's attention was focused on disrupting bureaucracy in Washington, the broad-based effort to slash the government workforce was impacting a far wider swath of workers. As layoff notices were sent out agency by agency, federal employees from Michigan to Florida were left reeling from being told that their services were no longer needed.

In a sign of how chaotic the fir-

ings have been, some who received layoff notices had already accepted the administration's deferred resignation offer, under which they were supposed to be paid until Sept. 30 if they agreed to quit, raising questions about whether others who signed the deal would nonetheless be fired. On Friday evening, the Office of Personnel Management, which serves as a human resources department for the federal government, acknowledged that some employees may have received termination notices in error and said the buyout agreements would be honored.

"This has been slash and burn," said Nicholas Detter, who had been working in Kansas as a natural resource specialist, helping farmers reduce soil and water erosion, until he was fired by email late Thursday night. He said there seemed to be little thought about how employees and the farmers and ranchers he

JOBS, Page A6

Mel Robbins and the appeal of her self-help message

Simple directions for change find a willing audience

By Beth Teitell
GLOBE STAFF

It was 15 degrees out, and the road salt was doing a number on the women's shoes, but it didn't matter, because they were here now, and delirious, some 1,300 of them, at Big Night Live on Causeway Street.

Over the sound system, Dua Lipa was pumping them up, not that any pumping was needed. And suddenly, there she was, Mel Robbins, the author of a new self-help book that Oprah herself called "one of the best I've ever read."

She was making her way to the stage, blowing kisses to the heavens, a rock star, but also something more, a savior. The middle-aged moms were screaming like teenagers and clamoring for selfies, and the hugs were flying, while Robbins's video team was capturing it all for her 24 million followers. And if their lives weren't perfect, well at this glorious moment, no one was feeling any pain.

"I love you, Mel!" someone cried out.

And then, it was happening: Rob-



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF

bins took the stage. In the melee, her shirt had become untucked. "Holy [expletive]," she said by way of hello to the audience and her on-stage conversational partner, Kiss 108's Lisa Donovan, the founder of the book club that had landed Robbins for the

ROBBINS, Page A10

Author Mel Robbins greeted fans as she entered an event at Big Night Live in Boston recently.

Pandemic shock still felt in N.E. schools

Report says students are half a grade behind

By Christopher Huffaker
GLOBE STAFF

Elementary and middle school students throughout New England are about a half grade behind in math and reading compared to students from the pre-pandemic era, according to a new analysis of academic performance.

The results of the third annual Education Recovery Scorecard released this week underscore how the aftershocks of the pandemic shutdowns continue to this day, raising the prospect that a generation of students might never recover the learning lost over the last five years, let alone achieve the highs of a decade ago.

Student performance in reading is still declining, suggesting that schools, on the whole, are teaching students less than they used to. And while scores have recovered somewhat in math, they remain far below prior peaks.

"The losses are not just due to what happened during the 2021 school year, but the aftershocks that have hit schools in the years since the pandemic," said Tom Kane, a Harvard economist who worked on the analysis. "Most

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